WILD GRAPE DUMPLINGS
WITH PECAN BRITTLE

serves 4 to 6

Many Cherokee and Chickasaw cookbooks feature a version of these grape dumplings, known as panki' alhfola' in Chickasaw. Today, they are often made with all-purpose flour and butter. Traditionally, though, they featured corn. This recipe leans more traditional but takes advantage of a modern convenience: high-quality masa harina. Combined with cassava flour's satisfying chewiness, these dumplings are especially delicious coated in a deep purple sauce made from fresh grapes.

To flavor the sauce, I add a little bit of wild ginger, which you can substitute with fresh ginger. A crunchy maple-pecan brittle finishes off the dessert.

BRITTLE

- ½ cup maple syrup
- ¼ teaspoon sea salt
- 1½ cups pecan halves (5 ounces), coarsely chopped

DUMPLINGS

- ¾ cup masa harina, plus more for rolling
- ¼ cup cassava flour
- 1 teaspoon baking powder
- ⅛ teaspoon sea salt
- 3 tablespoons sunflower oil
- 1½ teaspoons maple syrup

SAUCE

- 2 cups Muscadine grapes or other purple grapes, preferably wild (they don't need to be seedless)
- 2 cups Muscadine or other purple grape juice
- 1 small piece wild ginger, scrubbed and coarsely chopped, or a couple of ¼-inch-thick slices fresh ginger
- 2 tablespoons maple syrup

Make the brittle: Preheat the oven to 325°F. Line a baking sheet with a silicone baking mat or parchment paper.

In a small saucepan, combine the maple syrup and salt and cook over medium-high heat until the syrup reaches 250°F on an instant-read thermometer. Carefully stir in the pecans, then quickly scrape the mixture onto the lined baking sheet. Using a spatula, spread it in a single layer.

Transfer to the oven and bake for about 15 minutes, or until the brittle is dry to the touch. Let cool completely.

Make the dumplings: In a bowl, stir together the masa harina, cassava flour, baking powder, and salt. Add ½ cup water, the oil, and maple syrup and stir together to form a soft, springy dough.

Divide the dough into 24 equal portions and roll into balls. Place them on a baking sheet and lightly flatten each with your palm. Cover with a clean towel to prevent them from drying out.

Make the sauce: In a wide, shallow, heavy-bottomed pan, combine the grapes, 1 cup of the grape juice, and the ginger over medium-high heat. Bring to a boil and cook for about 1 minute, until most of the grapes have burst. Turn off the heat and use a masher or large spoon to help break up any whole grapes.

Strain through a fine-mesh sieve into a bowl, reserving the solids for composting. Return the grape juice mixture to the pan and stir in the remaining 1 cup of grape juice and the maple syrup. Cook over medium heat for about 10 minutes, or until the liquid is slightly thickened.

Carefully add the dumplings to the pan and turn to coat with the sauce. Cover and cook over low to medium heat for 10 minutes, gently flipping halfway using a spoon, until they're no longer raw in the center when you cut one in half.

Coarsely chop or break up the cooled pecan brittle and scatter over the dumplings. Serve warm with the sauce.